

ANXIETY & BIG EMOTIONS WORKBOOK FOR KIDS

Worry Monster, Breathing Techniques & Coping Strategies

By Daniel Tesfamariam

UNDERSTANDING BIG EMOTIONS

All feelings are okay. All behaviors are NOT okay.

It's okay to feel angry. It's NOT okay to hit.

It's okay to feel scared. It's NOT okay to scream at others.

It's okay to feel sad. It's NOT okay to break things.

THE FEELINGS THERMOMETER:

5 = EXPLODING (out of control, can't think)

4 = VERY HOT (about to lose it)

3 = WARM (getting frustrated/worried)

2 = COOL (a little uncomfortable)

1 = CALM (feeling good, in control)

Right now I'm at: ____ My goal is to get to: ____

MEET YOUR WORRY MONSTER

Everyone has a Worry Monster in their brain. It's trying to keep you SAFE, but sometimes it gets TOO loud about things that aren't actually dangerous.

My Worry Monster's name: _____

What it looks like: _____

What it usually says to me: _____

TALKING BACK TO YOUR WORRY MONSTER:

Worry says: "Something bad will happen!"

I say: "Maybe, maybe not. I can handle it."

Worry says: "Everyone is looking at you!"

I say: "Most people are thinking about themselves."

Worry says: "You can't do it!"

I say: "I've done hard things before. I can try."

5 BREATHING TECHNIQUES FOR KIDS

1. BALLOON BREATH:

Breathe in through nose (inflate your belly like a balloon)

Breathe out through mouth slowly (deflate the balloon)

Repeat 5 times

2. SQUARE BREATHING:

Breathe in for 4 counts | Hold for 4 counts

Breathe out for 4 counts | Hold for 4 counts

Trace a square in the air while you do it

3. FLOWER & CANDLE:

Smell the flower (breathe in through nose)

Blow out the candle (breathe out through mouth)

4. 5-4-3-2-1 GROUNDING:

5 things you SEE | 4 things you TOUCH

3 things you HEAR | 2 things you SMELL | 1 thing you TASTE

5. STARFISH BREATH:

Spread fingers like a starfish. Trace up each finger (breathe in)

Trace down each finger (breathe out). 5 breaths total!

MY COPING TOOLBOX

When I feel BIG emotions, I can try:

BODY tools:

- Jump 10 times
- Squeeze a stress ball
- Run in place
- Push against a wall (10 seconds)
- Drink cold water

MIND tools:

- Count backwards from 10
- Name 5 animals
- Think of my favorite place
- Remember: this feeling will pass
- Talk to my worry monster

COMFORT tools:

- Hug my stuffed animal
- Go to my calm corner
- Listen to my calm playlist
- Draw how I feel
- Ask for a hug

CALM CORNER SETUP GUIDE

Every child needs a safe place to go when emotions get big:

What to include:

- Soft pillows or beanbag
- Noise-canceling headphones
- Feelings chart (posted on wall)
- Breathing tool (pinwheel, bubbles)
- Fidget tools (putty, tangle)
- Weighted stuffed animal
- Journal or drawing pad
- Calm-down jar (glitter + water)

Rules for the calm corner:

- This is NOT a punishment
- You can go here anytime you need it
- Stay as long as you need
- Come out when you feel at level 1-2

DAILY FEELINGS CHECK-IN

Circle how you feel today:

HAPPY SAD ANGRY SCARED EXCITED FRUSTRATED CALM LONELY

My feeling level (1-5): ____

What happened: _____

What I did to cope: _____

Did it help? ☐ YES ☐ A LITTLE ☐ NO

Tomorrow I want to feel: _____

WORRY JAR EXERCISE

Write each worry on a slip of paper. Put it in your Worry Jar.
Once a week, open the jar with a parent and sort:

WORRY: _____

Did it come true? ☐ YES ☐ NO

Can I control it? ☐ YES ☐ NO

Action I can take: _____

Let it go? ☐ YES (tear it up!)

WORRY: _____

Did it come true? ☐ YES ☐ NO

Can I control it? ☐ YES ☐ NO

Action I can take: _____

Let it go? ☐ YES (tear it up!)

By Daniel Tesfamariam | Feelings are visitors. Let them come and go.